she commands the sympathy of its conservative social opinion. It may be, however, that -- for the very long term -- the strength of this position is more apparent than real. It is commonly believed in the United States that Britain's strength in the Middle East has been undermined by a record of thorough-going exploitation. We believe this charge to be untrue -- though Britain does assist her own business interests and does protect the vested rights of large British companies. The real weakness in Britain's position derives, in our judgment, from her lack of imagination and drive in development work. It is easy for the domestic upper classes of the Middle East to arouse the masses to political demonstrations against Britain under the slogan of freedom from the foreign yoke because nothing that Britain has done for any of her wards strikes the popular imagination as reflecting a profound concern about transforming them into a literate, healthy, prosperous, self-reliant people. It may be therefore that -- in the very long run -- Russian appeal to the masses will prove a greater source of strength in the Middle East than Britain's political ties, her business interests, and her social hold over the upper classes.

THE DESERT BACKGROUND

The dominant fact of the economic life of the Middle East is aridity. Of its total area of 2.6 million square miles, less than one-quarter receives an average annual rainfall of over 5 inches (125 millimeters). Only in some of its coastal plains and highland valleys are there broad stretches of land that receive enough rain to be cultivated fairly intensively without irrigation. In ancient Egypt and Mesopotamia (the modern Iraq) great States were established on the basis of a highly-skilled irrigation system. In Egypt the continuity of large-scale irrigation has never been broken, and a large population has persisted along the thin green ribbon created by the Nile (and the work of man) in the waste of the Egyptian desert. In Mesopotamia the irrigation system has been broken down by political disorders, population has declined to less than